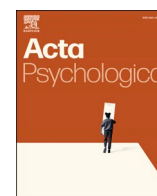




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Benefits or costs? The influence of gig employees' social comparison on organizational commitment via benign and malicious envy

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ABSTRACT

Previous research has suggested that employing labor from outside the organization can potentially mitigate the social comparison costs associated with internal incentive structures. However, with the development of the gig economy, gig employees and formal employees are interacting more frequently, leading to the emergence of social comparison costs among gig employees. To understand this new phenomenon, we draw on social comparison theory, investigating how gig employees engage in both upward and downward social comparison with formal employees and inducing both beneficial and harmful emotions and subsequently affecting organizational commitment. Using three-wave survey data collected from 525 gig employees in a leading Chinese internet company, we find that gig employee's upward (downward) comparison with formal employees can positively (negatively) affect gig employee's organizational commitment through benign (malicious) envy. Additionally, the competitive psychological climate positively (negatively) moderates the relationship between gig employee's upward (downward) comparison and benign (malicious) envy. The results broaden our understanding of social comparison in gig background, and contribute to a deeper understanding of the emotional responses generated by social comparisons by linking social comparison literature and envy literature.

1. Introduction

An increasing number of organizations are employing a mix of formal and gig employees with skills tailored to each project's specific needs (Bunjak et al., 2021). Knowledge-intensive corporations such as Microsoft, Meituan, and Tencent have increasingly adopted gig workers, who fill a variety of roles, including IT, operations, and technical experts on critical projects. Unlike prior research that focuses mainly on formal employees, we examine gig employees, while prior literature often uses terms such as contingent workers or temporary employees to describe individuals outside of traditional organizations, recent work has suggested that gig employees represent an emerging inclusive concept that captures various non-standard work forms (Caza et al., 2022). Our study goes beyond this general category by focusing specifically on knowledge-intensive gig employees, who differ substantially from the low-skilled gig workers emphasized in most existing studies. Knowledge-intensive gig employees are typically engaged in project-

based roles requiring specialized expertise (e.g., IT, data analysis, operations), work closely with formal employees on core organizational tasks, and directly influence organizational outcomes. This embedded interaction creates unique conditions for social comparison, as these workers simultaneously confront identity disadvantages and professional interdependence. Unlike contingent or temporary employees who often remain peripheral, knowledge-intensive gig employees engage in more prominent and complex comparisons with formal employees that extend beyond pay and job stability to include professional identity, skill recognition, and organizational belonging. This distinct context highlights the conceptual novelty of our study.

However, research has shown that the rise in gig employment has not significantly improved organizational efficiency or reduced costs as expected (e.g., Heeks et al., 2021). This gap may arise from the overlooked social comparison costs between gig and formal employees, which can influence the attitudes and efforts of gig workers. This challenges the traditional view that outsourcing—such as hiring gig

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employees—serves as a strategy to minimize social comparison costs (Nickerson & Zenger, 2008). In fact, when knowledge-based gig employees and formal employees interact more frequently, gig employees inevitably engage in social comparisons with formal employees. Specifically, gig employees may use these social comparisons to better position themselves within the organization, but they may also feel threatened by these comparisons, leading to lower commitment and contributions to the organization. As Nickerson and Zenger (2008) emphasized, social comparisons can have negative effects, such as envy and reduced cooperation. Given this, we particularly focus on the following questions: Do gig employees engage in social comparisons with formal employees? What forms of social comparison do they engage in, and what are the beneficial or harmful consequences of these comparisons? Addressing these comparisons is crucial for managing the diverse and multifaceted workforce of today's gig economy.

Social comparison theory distinguishes between upward and downward comparisons, each capable of producing either assimilation (striving to be like the target) or contrast (emphasizing dissimilarity) effects (Blanton, 2013; Collins, 1996). For gig employees—whose needs for security and belonging are often unmet compared to formal employees with greater stability and organizational acceptance (Caza et al., 2018; Wu & Huang, 2024)—such comparisons are particularly salient. Upward comparisons may activate assimilation and thus benign envy, motivating self-improvement and enhancing organizational commitment, whereas downward comparisons are more likely to elicit contrast and malicious envy, undermining commitment (Smith & Kim, 2007; Van de Ven et al., 2012). Because gig employees simultaneously compare themselves to formal employees in terms of both identity and competence (Suls & Wheeler, 2013), their emotional responses are complex. We therefore seek to identify which form of envy predominates, why these responses occur, and how they influence organizational commitment. Finally, drawing on evidence that contextual cues shape whether assimilation or contrast emerges (Stapel & Koomen, 2001), we propose that a competitive psychological climate serves as a boundary condition: by emphasizing performance-based attainability, it strengthens assimilation and weakens contrast (Lee et al., 2022; Schrock et al., 2016; Spurk et al., 2021).

This study contributes in three ways. First, we extend social comparison theory by examining how knowledge-intensive gig employees engage in social comparisons with formal employees and the emotional consequences of such comparisons. While Nickerson and Zenger (2008) originally proposed the concept of social comparison costs, they argued that hiring external workers—being outside the organizational boundary—can reduce such costs by limiting comparisons with internal employees. However, this assumption is increasingly challenged in the context of the growing gig economy. Today, gig employees often work closely with formal employees on shared tasks and projects, making frequent social comparisons inevitable. As gig workers become increasingly embedded in organizations, Connelly and Gallagher (2004) highlighted the rise of nonstandard employment arrangements; Devece et al. (2017) showed how gig work contributes to organizational flexibility; and Devece et al. (2019) further emphasized the growing influence of knowledge-intensive gig employees on firm outcomes; their comparisons with formal employees are not limited to compensation and job security, but also extend to recognition, influence, task autonomy, and belonging. Thus, social comparisons may persist between gig and formal employees, and produce both detrimental and beneficial consequences. Therefore, our study contributes to a more nuanced and updated understanding of social comparison in contemporary organizations by uncovering its emotional pathways and organizational implications in the gig context.

Second, we contribute to gig literature by linking social comparison and their organizational commitment. While gig employees are sometimes seen as detached from the organization due to their preference for flexibility (Cropanzano et al., 2023), organizations need to enhance these knowledge-based gig employees' commitment to the organization,

allowing gig employees to collaborate more effectively with colleagues and contribute their unique knowledge. We attempt to reveal the factors influencing gig employee's organizational commitment from the perspective of social comparison, helping organizations better manage gig employees.

Third, we contribute to research on gig employees by updating the understanding of organizational boundaries in the context of the gig economy. Traditionally, organizational boundaries have been defined administratively, based on formal employment contracts and legal status. However, with the rise of the gig economy, particularly the integration of knowledge-intensive gig employees into core teams, these boundaries are becoming increasingly blurred, porous, and socially constructed (Bunjak et al., 2021). By examining how knowledge-intensive gig employees engage in social comparison with formal employees, we demonstrate that these employees frequently cross traditional organizational boundaries both cognitively and relationally. Despite lacking formal employment status, they often participate in central workflows, collaborate on core projects, and experience affective and motivational consequences typically associated with formal employees. This finding suggests that organizational boundaries are no longer fixed lines but are continuously negotiated through day-to-day social interactions and perceptions of inclusion or exclusion. Thus, management behaviors and HR policies should be adaptive and inclusive, extending beyond contractual boundaries to address the needs and integration of all contributors.

2. Theory and hypotheses

2.1. Social comparison of gig employees

When delving into the complexities of organizational boundaries, researchers have traditionally emphasized the role of transaction costs in driving activities within firms, while also recognizing the presence of social comparison costs within these organizations (Zenger, 1992, 1994). These social comparison costs have been noted to hinder the ability of managers to optimize incentives and production structures internally, thus incentivizing the expansion of activities outside the organization, such as using gig employees (Nickerson & Zenger, 2008).

People have the fundamental need to establish their sense of identity and their position in their world (Hogg, 2000). In social contexts, individuals often engage in comparisons with others to gain insights into their relative status and position (Festinger, 1954). Gig employees find themselves situated in the ambiguous boundary zone within organizations, presenting them with a multitude of challenges, including identity challenges and career-path uncertainty (Caza et al., 2021). These challenges serve as potent motivators for gig employees to employ social comparisons as a means of confirming their identity, shaping their self-assessment, and self-improvement, and reducing uncertainty (Hogg, 2000; Luhtanen & Crocker, 1991; Thornton & Arrowood, 1966; Wheeler, 1991; Wills, 1981).

According to the relevant literature on social comparison, individuals utilize social comparison to construct their identity, gaining an awareness of who they are and how they are perceived (Hogg, 2000). Additionally, social comparison serves as a tool for reducing uncertainty in one's self-concept. Furthermore, individuals can satisfy their self-evaluation and self-enhancement needs through social comparison. For instance, individuals may employ downward comparison, comparing themselves to those who are worse than them, to enhance their self-esteem. Besides, engaging in upward comparisons with significantly more accomplished individuals does not necessarily diminish their self-esteem because they often categorize these superior others into a different, incomparable class (Luhtanen & Crocker, 1991; Thornton & Arrowood, 1966; Wheeler, 1991; Wills, 1981). Similarly, individuals can engage in upward comparisons, comparing themselves to those who are better, to enhance their self-concept (Wheeler, 1991).

Upon entering the corporate environment, gig employees experience

a complex interplay of social comparisons with formal employees. Our model suggests that such comparisons are not unidirectional shifts from upward to downward; instead, they co-occur in a multidimensional spectrum. Specifically, when gig employees encounter formal employees who outperform them, upward social comparisons are elicited. Formal employees typically enjoy stable positions, more defined organizational belonging, and greater access to core decision-making and team activities (Caza et al., 2018), which gig employees may lack due to their more peripheral roles. As a result, gig employees may view formal employees as role models, engaging in upward comparisons to identify areas for self-improvement or emulate behaviors that enhance their integration into the organization. Concurrently, when gig employees perceive themselves as excelling in specific domains, such as task expertise or professional skills, downward comparisons may come into play (Hogg, 2000; Suls & Wills, 2024). This is particularly evident among knowledge-based gig employees, who are often hired to supplement formal employees' expertise for specialized projects. These gig employees may see themselves as superior to formal employees in terms of technical competence or project contributions, using downward comparisons to maintain self-esteem and affirm their value. In summary, gig employees engage in both upward and downward social comparisons with formal employees.

2.2. Two kinds of envy

Rather than treating envy merely as a general psychological response, we focus on how it manifests in the gig-formal employee relationship. For gig employees, benign envy emerges when upward comparisons highlight attainable aspects of formal employees' positions, such as access to resources or organizational belonging. Conversely, malicious envy arises when downward comparisons remind gig employees that, despite their higher expertise, they remain excluded from stable roles and recognition. When gig employees engage in social comparisons with formal employees who own formal identity and position within the organization, one inevitable emotional experience that arises is envy (Duffy et al., 2021). Envy at its core is a form of social comparison where one perceives a lack of something that another possesses (van de Ven & Zeelenberg, 2020). Parrott and Smith (1993) proposed that envy can result in either a desire for what others have, known as benign envy, or an expectation that others will lose their advantage, known as malicious envy. Benign envy reflects a motivational drive in an individual to improve themselves and work harder to attain what others possess (van de Ven et al., 2009). In contrast, malicious envy involves a desire for the envied person to lose their advantages and may trigger destructive actions aimed at undermining the other person (van de Ven & Zeelenberg, 2020; Wu & Srite, 2021). Malicious envy includes negative evaluations of the envied individual (van de Ven et al., 2009) and can lead to actions aimed at weakening or attacking others (Lange & Crusius, 2015; van de Ven & Zeelenberg, 2015).

Past research has primarily focused on upward social comparisons as triggers for envy (Duffy et al., 2021; van de Ven & Zeelenberg, 2020). However, as researchers have increasingly distinguished between benign envy and malicious envy, the relationship between downward social comparisons and envy also warrants attention. Additionally, given the inherent identity differences between gig employees and formal employees, the subtle relationship between gig employee's social comparison with formal employees and their envy toward formal employees deserve exploration.

2.3. The benefits and costs of social comparison: the role of benign and malicious envy

Previous research has revealed the confounding outcomes stemming from directional comparison, where upward and downward comparisons can simultaneously attenuate or enhance certain results (e.g.,

Buunk et al., 1990, 2005). One possible explanation for these conflicting results pertains to whether social comparisons lead to a contrast effect (e.g., "that person is not me") or an assimilation effect (e.g., "that person could be me") (Collins, 1996, 2000). Specifically, past studies have generally suggested that when individuals engage in upward comparisons resulting in a contrast effect, emphasizing the differences between oneself and the comparison target leads to negative self-perceptions. Conversely, when individuals engage in upward comparisons resulting in an assimilation effect, emphasizing the similarities between oneself and the comparison target leads to positive self-perceptions (Blanton, 2013; Lockwood & Kunda, 1997; Stapel & Suls, 2004). Whether comparisons yield contrast or assimilation effects is influenced by numerous factors (e.g., Collins, 2000; Stapel & Koomen, 2005), including the attributes of the individual (e.g., self-certainty, Pelham & Wachsmuth, 1995), the attributes of the comparison target (e.g., Lockwood & Kunda, 1997, 1999; Stapel & Koomen, 2000), and the self-target relation (Brown et al., 1992; Tesser et al., 1988). An unresolved question pertains to whether there are any alterations in the contrast and assimilation effects when individuals confront comparison objects with objectively advantageous identities.

Moreover, these dynamics are deeply intertwined with the identity position of gig employees. Because they lack the formal status, security, and benefits enjoyed by full-time employees, gig workers face heightened identity threat and thus exhibit a stronger motivation to preserve self-esteem (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Petriglieri, 2011). When engaging in upward comparisons, gig employees often adopt similarity testing to highlight attainable aspects of formal employees' advantages (Mussweiler et al., 2004). Their distinct identity reduces the perception of direct threat, which shifts attention toward aspirational learning and fosters assimilation effects. This process generates benign envy, motivating gig employees to emulate role models and reinforcing their organizational commitment (Smith & Kim, 2007). By contrast, in downward comparisons, the situation reverses. Gig employees may surpass formal employees in expertise or productivity, yet remain excluded from the stable identity and institutional benefits attached to formal roles. This discrepancy intensifies identity threat, triggering dissimilarity testing and contrast effects. As a result, they may experience malicious envy, resenting formal employees' advantages despite their inferior skills (Van de Ven et al., 2012). Such resentment erodes cooperative behaviors and undermines organizational commitment. Thus, identity threat provides the missing link that explains why upward comparisons foster constructive emotions, while downward comparisons can produce destructive ones.

Firstly, we propose that upward comparisons between gig employees and formal employees are more likely to induce gig employee's benign envy. Gig employees, when engaging in upward social comparisons with formal employees, are likely to adopt similarity testing, actively seeking similarities between themselves and formal employees. This process triggers an assimilation effect (Mussweiler et al., 2004), whereby gig employees perceive formal employees' advantages—such as job stability, better access to resources, and stronger organizational belonging—as achievable through their own efforts (e.g., "that person could be me"). The assimilation effect encourages gig employees to view formal employees as role models, inspiring them to emulate their behaviors and achievements. This process fosters benign envy, a constructive emotional response characterized by admiration for the comparison target's success and a desire to achieve similar outcomes (Smith & Kim, 2007). Consequently, we propose **Hypothesis 1**:

Hypothesis 1. Gig employee's upward comparison with formal employees increases gig employee's benign envy toward formal employees.

Moreover, downward comparisons between gig employees and formal employees are likely to induce malicious envy. When gig employees engage in downward social comparisons, they often do so to emphasize their strengths relative to formal employees, thereby enhancing their self-esteem and maintaining a positive self-perception

(Hogg, 2000; Suls & Wills, 2024). Specifically, gig employees, particularly those with specialized skills, may perceive themselves as more competent or flexible than formal employees, especially in specific tasks or domains. This process involves dissimilarity testing, whereby gig employees highlight differences between themselves and formal employees, leading to a contrast effect (e.g., “that person is not like me”) (Blanton, 2013; Collins, 1996).

While contrast effects resulting from downward comparisons have been shown to foster positive self-perceptions (Blanton, 2013; Stapel & Suls, 2004), in the context of gig employees, such positive perceptions may conflict with their broader identity disadvantage—a perception of instability or exclusion from the organization's formal structure. Specifically, it is important to acknowledge that formal employees typically have more stable, recognized, and institutionalized roles within the organization, which can be perceived as a more established organizational identity compared to the often temporary and flexible nature of gig employees' roles. This conflict can intensify identity threats and give rise to negative emotions, such as malicious envy (Luhtanen & Crocker, 1991; Wheeler, 1991). Malicious envy involves a desire for the comparison target to lose their perceived advantages and is often accompanied by hostile attitudes or behaviors (van de Ven et al., 2012). Furthermore, when formal employees are perceived to occupy undeservedly stable or superior positions within the organization, gig employees may interpret these positions as unfair, further amplifying malicious envy (van de Ven & Zeelenberg, 2020). This envy reflects the tension between gig employees' positive self-perceptions derived from their strengths and their feelings of exclusion from the organizational core. Therefore, we propose **Hypothesis 2**:

Hypothesis 2. Gig employee's downward comparison with formal employees increases gig employee's malicious envy toward formal employees.

Furthermore, envy constitutes a significant influencing factor on gig employee's organizational commitment (Duffy & Shaw, 2000). Organizational commitment refers to the employee's emotional attachment to, identification with, and involvement in the organization (Allen & Meyer, 1990; Chen & Francesco, 2003). Cropanzano et al. (2023) pointed out that gig employees could be committed to varying targets, such as their job, staffing agencies, or even their personal life, rather than necessarily committing to the organization they work for. However, when organizations are able to provide sufficient positive emotion experiences related to the organization, they can effectively activate employees' commitment target to the organization (e.g., Li et al., 2010). Envy toward formal employees, as a significant emotional experience in the workplace, could serve as an important antecedent to gig employees' organizational commitment (Duffy & Shaw, 2000).

First, as indicated by **Hypothesis 1**, benign envy is a positive emotional mechanism triggered by upward social comparison. We further propose that benign envy can effectively enhance gig employees' organizational commitment. Benign envy reflects a willingness among gig employees to improve themselves to narrow the gap with formal employees (van de Ven et al., 2009). This drives gig employees to emulate the behaviors of formal employees, such as exhibiting greater work engagement, seeking skill development, and actively participating in organizational processes (Smith & Kim, 2007). As Li et al. (2010) noted, emotions like “guilt” and “determination” are significantly positively associated with organizational commitment. Under the influence of benign envy, gig employees not only gradually narrow the gap with formal employees but also emotionally align themselves more closely with the organization's goals and values.

Furthermore, as indicated by **Hypothesis 2**, malicious envy is a negative emotional mechanism triggered by downward social comparison. We further propose that malicious envy may reduce gig employees' organizational commitment. This type of envy is often accompanied by dissatisfaction among gig employees regarding the formal positions or resources held by formal employees (van de Ven et al., 2012). Previous

research suggests that malicious envy typically leads individuals to engage in destructive behaviors, such as social loafing, withdrawal, or non-cooperation (George, 1992). For gig employees, this emotion may weaken their emotional bonds and goal alignment with the organization (Latane et al., 1979). It not only hinders collaboration between gig and formal employees but may also exacerbate gig employees' sense of marginalization, making it more difficult for them to integrate into the organization. Additionally, malicious envy may prompt gig employees to realign their commitment targets, shifting their focus away from the organization toward more individualized goals, such as job flexibility or personal growth, as a substitute for organizational commitment (Cropanzano et al., 2023). Thus, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 3. Gig employee's benign envy toward formal employees mediates the relationship between gig employee's upward comparison and organizational commitment.

Hypothesis 4. Gig employee's malicious envy toward formal employees mediates the relationship between gig employee's downward comparison and organizational commitment.

2.4. Competitive psychological climate moderates gig employee's social comparison and envy

Social Comparison Theory (Festinger, 1954) suggests that whether social comparisons result in contrast or assimilation effects can be influenced by external contexts (Stapel & Koomen, 2005). Competitive psychological climate (CPC), as a contextual variable, implies that organizational rewards are contingent on individual performance (Brown et al., 1998; Nerstad et al., 2013) and signals potential advancement opportunities. CPC may help alleviate gig employees' perceived identity disadvantages. Specifically, gig employees are often positioned at the periphery of the organization. By emphasizing meritocracy, CPC provides opportunities for them to overcome identity barriers and reduces the negative emotions associated with perceived identity disadvantages. Additionally, CPC creates an environment where gig employees can stand out through effort, aligning with their pursuit of personal value and professional growth.

Social Comparison Theory (Festinger, 1954) suggests that whether social comparisons result in contrast or assimilation effects can be influenced by external contexts (Stapel & Koomen, 2005). Competitive psychological climate (CPC), as a boundary condition, implies that organizational rewards are contingent on individual performance (Brown et al., 1998; Nerstad et al., 2013) and signals potential advancement opportunities. CPC may help alleviate gig employees' perceived identity disadvantages. Specifically, gig employees are often positioned at the periphery of the organization. By emphasizing meritocracy, CPC provides opportunities for them to overcome identity barriers and reduces the negative emotions associated with perceived identity disadvantages. Additionally, CPC creates an environment where gig employees can stand out through effort, aligning with their pursuit of personal value and professional growth.

Specifically, on one hand, CPC can strengthen the positive relationship between upward social comparison and benign envy. Specifically, CPC enhances the perceived attainability of goals. According to social comparison theory, when individuals believe they can also achieve the success of their comparison target, upward comparisons lead to an assimilation effect (Lockwood & Kunda, 1997, 1999). In a high CPC environment, organizations emphasize that ability determines status (Brown et al., 1998; Nerstad et al., 2013), which makes gig employees more confident that the advantages of formal employees—such as job stability and access to resources—can be attained through effort. This, in turn, triggers the assimilation effect, causing gig employees to view formal employees as models for learning and imitation, which in turn fosters benign envy. In addition, gig employees may experience stronger motivation for self-improvement and set more challenging goals when they perceive this competitive climate (Brown et al., 1998). This drives

them to focus on the similarities they share with formal employees in upward comparisons, further intensifying benign envy (Smith & Kim, 2007). While upward comparisons can sometimes evoke threat and malicious envy (Lockwood & Kunda, 1997, 1999), our model explicitly incorporates competitive psychological climate (CPC) to address this concern. CPC functions as a boundary condition that determines whether upward comparisons are experienced as threatening or inspiring. In high-CPC contexts, where rewards are allocated on the basis of performance and contribution rather than contract type, gig employees perceive upward targets as more attainable and less identity-threatening. This increases the likelihood of assimilation and benign envy. Conversely, when CPC is low, structural barriers and status asymmetries remain salient, making benign envy less likely and leaving space for malicious envy to emerge. Thus, CPC is central to explaining the conditions under which upward comparisons generate constructive rather than destructive outcomes.

On the other hand, CPC can weaken the positive relationship between downward social comparison and malicious envy. First, when CPC is high, gig employees are more likely to perceive the advantages of formal employees as the result of competition rather than an insurmountable status difference (Nerstad et al., 2013). By signaling that “ability determines status” (Brown et al., 1998; Nerstad et al., 2013), CPC reduces gig employees’ perception of unfairness regarding the advantages of formal employees. This change in perception weakens the contrast effect induced by downward comparisons, thereby decreasing the occurrence of malicious envy. Second, CPC encourages gig employees to refocus on their own abilities. A competitive psychological climate emphasizes performance, which motivates gig workers to concentrate on improving their own capabilities rather than focusing on diminishing the status of formal employees to protect their self-esteem (Brown et al., 1998; Nerstad et al., 2013). CPC provides gig employees with a clear path to attain the resources and status that formal employees possess through effort and competition, rather than resorting to emotional responses, such as malicious envy, to cope with status differences. Thus, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 5. Competitive psychological climate moderates the relationship between gig employee’s upward comparison and their benign envy toward formal employees. Specifically, competitive psychological climate strengthens the positive relationship between gig employee’s upward comparison and their benign envy toward formal employees.

Hypothesis 6. Competitive psychological climate moderates the relationship between gig employee’s downward comparison and their malicious envy toward formal employees. Specifically, competitive psychological climate weakens the positive relationship between gig employee’s downward comparison and their malicious envy toward formal employees.

2.5. Moderated mediation model

Based on the arguments above, we further propose that competitive psychological climate moderates the mediation effects of upward (downward) social comparison on organizational commitment through the benign (malicious) envy pathways described above. We argue that the positive indirect effect of upward social comparison on organizational commitment through benign envy is stronger when competitive psychological climate is higher (vs. lower). Gig employees with a high perceived competitive psychological climate are more likely to experience assimilation effects following upward social comparison, thereby generating more benign envy, which further leads to higher organizational commitment. Meanwhile, when competitive psychological climate is higher (vs. lower), the negative indirect effect of downward social comparison on organizational commitment via malicious envy is weaker. Employees with higher perceived competitive psychological climate are less likely to experience contrast effects from downward

social comparison, and thus are less likely to generate malicious envy, which further prevents lower levels of organizational commitment. In summary, we propose that:

Hypothesis 7. Competitive psychological climate moderates the mediation effect of gig employee’s benign envy toward formal employees. Specifically, competitive psychological climate strengthens the indirect effect between gig employee’s upward comparison organizational commitment via their benign envy toward formal employees.

Hypothesis 8. Competitive psychological climate moderates the mediation effect of gig employee’s malicious envy toward formal employees. Specifically, competitive psychological climate weakens the indirect effect between gig employee’s downward comparison and organizational commitment via their malicious envy toward formal employees.

Fig. 1 provides an overview of the ideas that we test in our conceptual model.

3. Method

3.1. Sample and procedure

We tested the hypotheses using data obtained from gig employees within a Chinese shopping platform company which is a typical knowledge-intensive organization. Given the Chinese collectivist cultural context, the salience of identity differences between gig and formal employees may be especially pronounced, which reinforces the relevance of our setting for examining social comparison between gig employees and formal employees. These gig employees are defined as project-based external professionals who were not formally employed by the focal organization. Instead, they were contracted via third-party staffing platforms to temporarily join internal project teams when specific expertise (e.g., data science, product management) was required. Gig employee’s work encompasses roles such as IT contractors and internet operators, with responsibilities in areas like JAVA backend, web frontend, and test development, as well as user/product operations. These individuals worked full-time on-site during the project period but did not receive the same benefits or long-term career opportunities as formal employees. Once the project concluded, their engagement with the organization ended.

Data were collected by online questionnaires at three time-points over three months. Managers assisted in forwarding survey invitations. Participants were clearly informed that responses would be anonymous, used solely for academic research, and inaccessible to supervisors. Participation was entirely voluntary, and respondents could withdraw at any point. We emphasized before distribution that “your honest responses are critical for improving organizational management” to encourage accuracy. The sample covers 718 gig employees. At time 1, we invited the gig employees to report their upward and downward social comparison with formal employees. At time 2, one month after time 1, we invited gig employees to report their benign envy and malicious envy toward formal employees, as well as their perceived competitive psychological climate. At time 3, gig employees report their organizational commitment. The final matched sample consisted of 525 gig employees, with a response rate of 73.12 %. Among gig employees, the average age was 28.71 years, 21.21 % were female, 24.55 % had a high school degree or below, 59.4 % had a college degree and 16.05 % had a master degree, and their average tenure was 15 months.

We conducted an a priori power analysis in R (using the pwr package; Champely et al., 2020) to determine the required sample size for detecting our focal effect. Assuming a small effect size ($\Delta R^2 = 0.015$, corresponding to $f^2 = 0.021$), an alpha level of 0.05, and desired power of 0.80, the analysis indicated that a minimum of $N = 368$ participants would be required. Our final sample of 525 participants thus exceeded this threshold, suggesting that the study had adequate statistical power

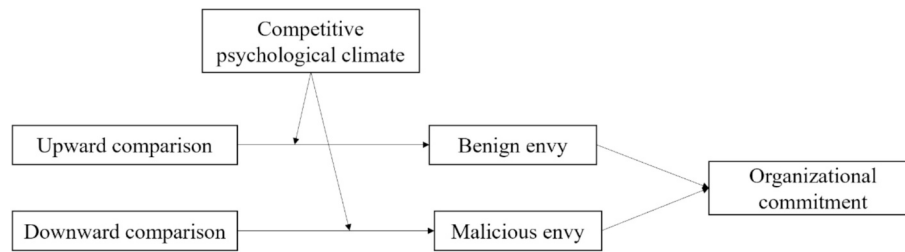


Fig. 1. The hypothesized theoretical model.

to detect the hypothesized effect.

3.2. Measures

All of the items were measured using a seven-point Likert scale, response format of 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree), unless otherwise noted. We used well-established measures for the proposed variables.

3.2.1. Gig employee upward comparison

At time 1, the gig employees reported their upward comparison with 6 items from Brown et al.'s (2007) scale. Participants were asked to indicate the frequency with which they compared themselves to other formal employees who were better off along six dimensions (job content, working conditions, benefits, career progression, influence, performance; $\alpha = 0.94$).

3.2.2. Gig employee downward comparison

At time 1, the gig employees reported their upward comparison with 6 items from Brown et al.'s (2007) scale. Participants were asked to indicate the frequency with which they compared themselves to other formal employees who were worse off along six dimensions ($\alpha = 0.98$).

3.2.3. Benign envy

At time 2, the gig employees reported their benign envy with four items from Lange et al.'s (2018) scale (e.g., "these formal employees motivated me to become just like him/her."; $\alpha = 0.87$).

3.2.4. Malicious envy

At time 2, the gig employees reported their malicious envy with four items from Lange et al.'s (2018) scale (e.g., "I felt hostile towards these formal employees." "I complained to someone else about these formal employees."; $\alpha = 0.89$).

3.2.5. Competitive psychological climate

At time 2, the gig employees reported their perceived competitive psychological climate with 3 items from Fletcher et al.'s (2008) scale (e.g., "My coworkers frequently compare their performance with mine."; $\alpha = 0.75$). The original scale included four items. One item ("Everyone wants to be the best-performing employee") was removed due to a negative factor loading in the exploratory factor analysis, and the remaining three items were retained.

3.2.6. Organizational commitment

At time 3, the gig employees reported their organizational commitment with 8 items adapted from Chen and Francesco's (2003) scale (e.g., "I feel a strong sense of belonging to my organization" "I feel emotionally attached to this organization"; $\alpha = 0.94$).

3.2.7. Control variables¹

We controlled for education level, gender, age, tenure, prior formal employment experience,² and perceived expertise. These variables may influence employees' social comparisons, envy experiences, and organizational commitment (Gibbons & Buunk, 1999). Perceived expertise was measured with a three-item scale (Li et al., 2019; $\alpha = 0.96$; e.g., "I have the expertise to work on this project"). This scale captures individuals' subjective perceptions of expertise. Compared to objective expertise, subjective expertise more directly shapes how individuals interpret social comparisons (Jipp, 2016). Other demographic variables were included because they may influence social comparison tendencies and employee's emotional reactions. For example, higher education are associated with greater self-confidence and upward comparison (Pressley et al., 1989; Ritchie et al., 2015), gender may shape emotional responses to comparison, and tenure, age, and prior formal job experience may increase opportunities and sensitivity to workplace comparisons and commitment expectations.

4. Results

Table I shows the means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations of the data. Before testing our hypotheses, we conducted confirmatory factor analyses (CFA) using Mplus Version 8.3 to examine the distinctiveness of the variables rated by the gig employees. The CFA results are shown in Table II. The hypothesized six-factor model fit the data better ($\chi^2(419) = 1604.450$, RMSEA = 0.073, CFI = 0.930, TLI = 0.922, SRMR = 0.044). To further address concerns about common method bias, we conducted a Harman's single-factor test on all variables. The results showed that the first principal component is 25.458 %, which is less than 40 % of the total variance, indicating that common method variance is not a major threat to our findings (Podsakoff et al., 2003). In addition, we followed the recommendation of Miller and Simmering (2023) and included attitude toward the color blue as a marker variable to test for common method bias (CMB). We adopted the three items with the highest factor loadings from the attitude toward the color blue scale developed by Miller and Simmering (2023) as the marker variable (e.g., "Blue is a lovely color", $\alpha = 0.83$). As shown in Table III, the results indicate that CMB is not a serious concern in our data, supporting the validity of subsequent hypothesis testing.

We used Mplus Version 8.3 to test the hypotheses. Hypothesis 1 states that gig employee's upward comparison with formal employees increases gig employee's benign envy toward formal employees. As shown in Table IV (Model 1), the coefficient of upward comparison on benign envy is positive and significant, with a relative small effect size ($\gamma = 0.11$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .01$). Therefore, Hypothesis 1 was supported. Specifically, as gig employees engage more in upward comparison with formal employees, they tend to experience greater levels of benign envy. As Bosco et al. (2015) demonstrated in a meta-analysis of over 147,000 correlations, effect sizes around $\gamma = 0.10$ – 0.25 are typical and practically

¹ Our results remain robust even when these control variables are not included in models.

² Coded as 0 = no prior formal employee experience, 1 = yes

Table I
Descriptive statistics and correlations.

Variable	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1. Age	28.71	3.98											
2. Gender	1.21	0.40	−0.14*										
3. Education	3.24	0.63	−0.16*	0.16*									
4. Tenure	1.22	1.06	0.19**	0.10	0.00								
5. Expertise	5.49	1.01	−0.01	−0.01	0.01	0.14**							
6. FF	0.31	0.46	0.02	−0.01	0.03	−0.10*	−0.05						
7. Upward comparison	3.69	1.34	0.02	0.02	0.05	−0.00	0.08	0.02					
8. Downward comparison	2.91	1.45	0.03	−0.12*	−0.07	0.02	0.02	0.00	0.55**				
9. Benign envy	5.69	1.01	−0.01	0.00	−0.03	0.02	0.26**	0.03	0.13**	−0.05			
10. Malicious envy	1.82	1.07	0.08	−0.19**	−0.10*	−0.01	−0.13**	−0.07	0.16**	0.28**	−0.32**		
11. Competitive psychological climate	3.54	1.17	0.15*	−0.11	−0.02	0.01	−0.02	0.04	0.44**	0.45**	−0.02	0.21**	
12. Organizational commitment	5.30	1.11	−0.01	−0.10	−0.07	0.03	0.42**	−0.01	0.07	−0.02	0.36**	−0.14**	0.02

Note. $N = 525$. Education was measured categorically (1 = Below High School; 2 = High School; 3 = Associate Degree (Junior College); 4 = Bachelor's Degree; 5 = Master's Degree; 6 = Doctorate). FE = Formal Experience.

* $p < .05$.

** $p < .01$.

Table II
Results of confirmatory factor analysis.

Model	χ^2	df	RMSEA	CFI	TLI	SRMR	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δdf
Six-factor model	1604.450	419	0.073	0.930	0.922	0.044		
Five-factor model 1	2961.832	424	0.107	0.850	0.836	0.107	282.30***	5
Five-factor model 2	3834.336	424	0.124	0.799	0.779	0.101	872.50	0
Four-factor model	5189.523	428	0.146	0.719	0.695	0.129	235.51***	4
Three-factor model	5688.712	431	0.152	0.690	0.665	0.162	264.70***	3
Two-factor model	6919.511	433	0.169	0.617	0.589	0.191	118.87***	2
One-factor model	10,740.737	434	0.213	0.392	0.349	0.233	107.19***	1

Note. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$; $N = 525$; TLI = Tucker–Lewis index; CFI = comparative fit index; RMSEA = root mean square error of approximation; SRMR = standardized root mean square residual. Five-factor model 1: gig employee upward comparison + gig employee downward comparison, benign envy, malicious envy, competitive psychological climate, organizational commitment; Five-factor model 2: gig employee upward comparison, gig employee downward comparison, benign envy + malicious envy, competitive psychological climate, organizational commitment; Four-factor model: gig employee upward comparison + gig employee downward comparison, benign envy + malicious envy, competitive psychological climate, organizational commitment; Three-factor model: gig employee upward comparison + gig employee downward comparison, benign envy + malicious envy, competitive psychological climate + organizational commitment; Two-factor model: gig employee upward comparison + gig employee downward comparison + benign envy + malicious envy, competitive psychological climate + organizational commitment; One-factor model: gig employee upward comparison + gig employee downward comparison + benign envy + malicious envy + competitive psychological climate + organizational commitment.

Table III
Marker variable analysis.

Model	χ^2	df	CFI	TLI	RMSEA	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δdf
Baseline model	1684.780	514	0.934	0.928	0.066		
C model	1832.227	513	0.926	0.919	0.070	147.447***	1
U model	1754.885	492	0.929	0.919	0.070	77.342***	21
R model	1757.021	517	0.930	0.924	0.068	2.136	25

Note. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$; $N = 525$; TLI = Tucker–Lewis index; CFI = comparative fit index; RMSEA = root mean square error of approximation; SRMR = standardized root mean square residual.

meaningful for relations involving psychological or attitudinal constructs. Thus, the observed effect sizes in our study may be considered reasonable. Moreover, given that these predictors are malleable through interventions (e.g., control the interaction frequency between gig and formal employees, or build different team climate), even small effects may have substantial cumulative impact across large organizations (Bosco et al., 2015). Accordingly, we elaborate on feasible intervention strategies in the Practical Implications section.

Hypothesis 2 states that the gig employee's downward comparison with formal employees is positively related to gig employee's malicious envy toward formal employees. As shown in Table IV (Model 3), the coefficient of downward comparison on malicious envy is positive and significant, with a moderate effect size ($\gamma = 0.27$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .001$). Therefore, **Hypothesis 2** was supported. This result indicates that when gig employees compare themselves with formal employees who are less

competent or lower-performing, it may generate frustration and resentment, leading to more destructive emotional responses (i.e., malicious envy).

Hypothesis 3 posits that the gig employee's benign envy toward formal employees plays mediating role between the gig employee's upward comparison with formal employees and organizational commitment. As shown in Table V, the indirect effect of upward comparison on organizational commitment through benign envy was significant (95 % CI = [0.006, 0.055]). Therefore, **Hypothesis 3** was supported. **Hypothesis 4** posits that the gig employee's malicious envy toward formal employees plays mediating role between the gig employee's downward comparison with formal employees and organizational commitment. As shown in Table V, the indirect effect of downward comparison on organizational commitment through malicious envy was significant (95 % CI = [−0.051, −0.001]). Thus, **Hypothesis 4** was supported. These findings

Table IV
Regression analyses.

Variable	Benign envy		Malicious envy		Organizational commitment	
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Intercept	4.19*** (0.58)	4.51*** (0.54)	1.75*** (0.54)	2.41*** (0.53)	2.53*** (0.75)	4.14*** (0.75)
Predictor variables						
Education	−0.04 (0.04)	−0.04 (0.04)	−0.07* (0.04)	−0.07 (0.04)	−0.10 (0.06)	−0.13 (0.06)
Expertise	0.26*** (0.04)	0.24*** (0.04)	−0.14** (0.04)	−0.13*** (0.04)	0.37*** (0.06)	0.40*** (0.05)
Tenure	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.02 (0.04)	−0.07 (0.06)	0.05 (0.06)
Age	−0.30 (0.96)	−0.15 (0.96)	1.35 (0.95)	1.06 (0.95)	−0.05 (0.06)	−0.05 (0.06)
Gender	0.26 (0.96)	0.10 (0.96)	−1.36 (0.95)	−1.07 (0.95)	−0.09 (0.06)	−0.11 (0.06)
FE	0.05 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)	−0.08 (0.04)	−0.08* (0.04)	−0.01 (0.06)	−0.02 (0.06)
Upward Comparison	0.11** (0.04)	0.17*** (0.05)			−0.02 (0.07)	
Downward comparison			0.27*** (0.04)	0.23*** (0.05)		−0.01 (0.07)
Competitive Psychological Climate (CPC)		−0.09* (0.05)		0.09* (0.05)	0.01 (0.07)	0.04 (0.07)
Benign envy					0.27*** (0.06)	
Malicious envy						−0.11 (0.06)
Interaction						
Upward Comparison* CPC		0.12** (0.04)			0.05 (0.06)	
Downward comparison* CPC				−0.11* (0.04)		−0.09 (0.06)
R ²	0.08*** (0.02)	0.10*** (0.03)	0.11*** (0.03)	0.12*** (0.03)	0.25*** (0.04)	0.23*** (0.05)

Note. *N* = 525. FE = Formal Experience. The estimates reported are standardized coefficients; standard errors are displayed in parentheses.

* *p* < .05.
** *p* < .01.
*** *p* < .001.

Table V
Results of the mediation model.

	Path a	Path b	Direct effect [95 % CI]	Indirect effect [95 % CI]
Upward comparison	0.11** (0.04)	0.27*** (0.04)	0.00 (0.04) [−0.076, 0.084]	0.03* (0.01) [0.006, 0.055]
Downward comparison	0.27*** (0.04)	−0.10* (0.05)	−0.01 (0.05) [−0.103, 0.091]	−0.03* (0.01) [−0.051, −0.001]

Note. *N* = 525. Dependent variable is organizational commitment.

* *p* < .05.
** *p* < .01.
*** *p* < .001.

further connect gig employees' social comparison behaviors to critical organizational outcomes (i.e., organizational commitment), and highlight emotional experiences (particularly envy) as a pivotal mediating mechanism in this relationship.

Hypothesis 5 posits a positive moderating effect of competitive psychological climate. As shown in **Table IV** (Model 2), the interaction

term between upward comparison and competitive psychological climate had a significant effect on benign envy ($\gamma = 0.12$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .01$). Therefore, **Hypothesis 5** received support. **Hypothesis 6** posits a negative moderating effect of competitive psychological climate. As shown in **Table IV** (Model 4), the interaction term of downward comparison and competitive psychological climate had a significant

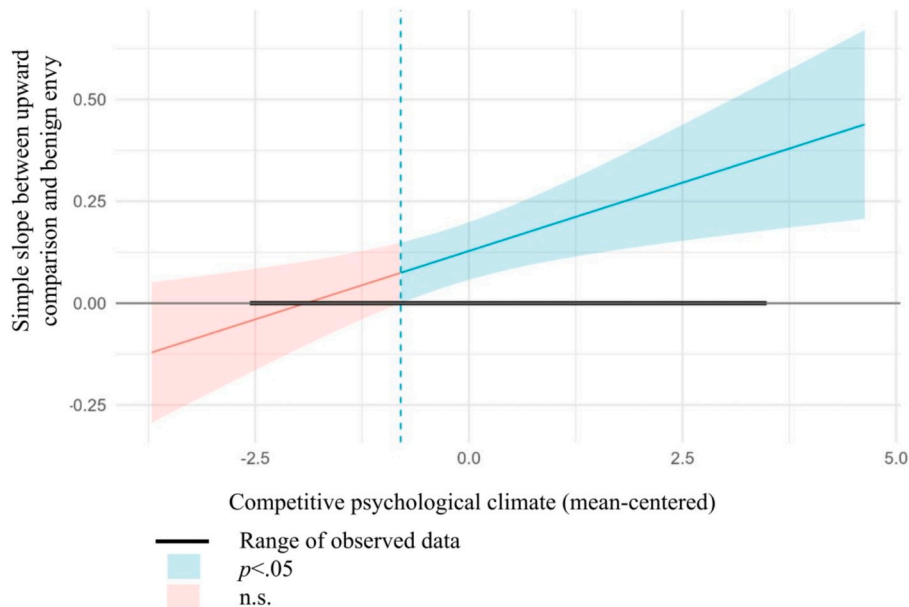


Fig. 2. Competitive psychological climate as moderator of upward comparison on benign envy.

negative effect on malicious envy ($\gamma = -0.11$, $SE = 0.04$, $p < .05$). Therefore, Hypothesis 6 received support. We further employed the Johnson–Neyman technique to pinpoint the levels of CPC at which the simple slopes become statistically significant (Preacher et al., 2006). As shown in Fig. 2, the simple slopes became significant when the mean-centered CPC was ≥ -0.80 , indicating that gig employees with CPC above this threshold experience more benign envy when making upward comparisons with formal employees. Similarly, as shown in Fig. 3, the simple slopes became nonsignificant when mean-centered CPC was ≥ 2.06 , indicating that gig employees above this CPC threshold did not experience higher malicious envy when making downward comparisons with formal employees.

Hypothesis 7 and 8 posits positive moderated mediation effects. As shown in Table VI, when competitive psychological climate is high (+1SD), the indirect relationship between upward comparison and organizational commitment through benign envy is significantly positive (indirect effect = 0.09, $SE = 0.03$, 95 %CI = [0.031, 1.390]); when competitive psychological climate is low (−1SD), the indirect relationship is not significant (indirect effect = 0.003, $SE = 0.02$, 95 %CI = [−0.001, 0.069]). The difference is also significant (difference = 0.05, $SE = 0.02$, 95 %CI = [0.008, 0.095]). Therefore, Hypothesis 7 received support. When competitive psychological climate is high (+1SD), the indirect relationship between downward comparison and organizational commitment through malicious envy is not significant (indirect effect = −0.01, $SE = 0.01$, 95 %CI = [−0.024, 0.007]); when competitive psychological climate is low (−1SD), the indirect relationship is significantly negative (indirect effect = −0.03, $SE = 0.02$, 95 %CI = [−0.066, 0.007]). The difference is not significant (difference = 0.02, $SE = 0.01$, 95 %CI = [−0.007, 0.049]). Therefore, Hypothesis 8 is not supported. Although our results supported the moderated mediation pathway through benign envy (H7), the pathway through malicious envy (H8) was not statistically significant. This asymmetry invites further theoretical reflection. One possible explanation lies in the collectivist cultural context of our sample, which may suppress the expression or reporting of malicious envy. From a methodological perspective, restricted variance in malicious envy scores could also have attenuated the observed effects. Future research could explore whether other moderators, such as perceived justice, psychological safety, or personality traits, might better explain when and why malicious envy mediates the link between comparison and commitment. It may also be fruitful to

Table VI
Moderated mediation analyses of the indirect effect.

Moderator	Indirect effect [95 % CI]	Difference in indirect effect [95 % CI]
	Upward Comparison-Benign envy-Organizational commitment	
Low CPC	0.03(0.02) [−0.001, 0.069]	0.05*(0.02) [0.008, 0.095]
High CPC	0.09**(0.03) [0.031, 0.139]	
	Downward Comparison-Malicious envy-Organizational commitment	
Low CPC	−0.03(0.02) [−0.066, 0.007]	0.02(0.01) [−0.007, 0.049]
High CPC	−0.01(0.01) [−0.024, 0.007]	

Note. $N = 525$. The estimates reported are unstandardized coefficients. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$.

adopt qualitative or multi-source methods to capture subtler forms of negative emotion and their downstream effects.

5. Discussion

This study provided evidence for the social comparison between gig employees and formal employees. More precisely, our study investigates that gig employees engage in both upward and downward social comparisons while collaborating with formal employees. The upward social comparison induces gig employee's benign envy toward formal employees and thus increases their organizational commitment. While downward social comparison induces gig employee's malicious envy toward formal employees and thus impairs their organizational commitment. Competitive psychological climate strengthened the relationship between upward social comparison and benign envy, and weakened the relationship between downward social comparison and malicious envy. These relationships were unique to gig employee's social comparison and extended understanding of these knowledge-intensive gig employee's behavior and psychological mechanism.

5.1. Theoretical implications

Our study contributes to the emerging gig work literature in four ways. First, our study contributes to the emerging gig work literature by refining how social comparison theory applies in the new context of the gig economy. Gig employees are increasingly integrated within organizational boundaries, engaging in frequent interactions with formal

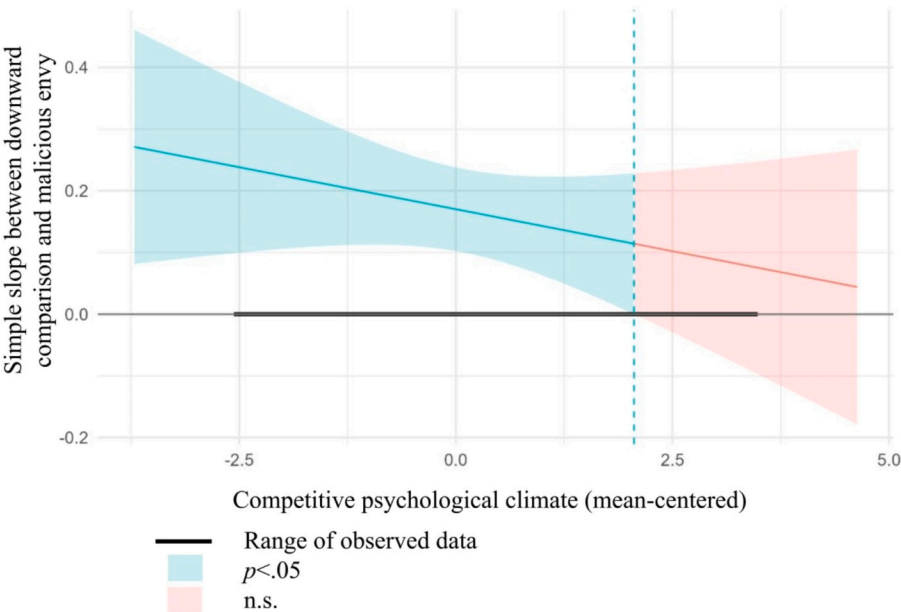


Fig. 3. Competitive psychological climate as moderator of downward comparison on malicious envy.

employees and influencing organizational outcomes (Caza et al., 2018, 2021). Against this backdrop, we challenge the traditional outsourcing perspective by showing that, in the context of knowledge-intensive gig employees who closely interact with formal employees, outsourcing does not necessarily minimize social comparison costs. Nevertheless, substantial identity differences persist between the two groups (Caza et al., 2021), providing fertile ground for complex social comparisons. We show that gig employees engage in both upward and downward comparisons with distinct consequences. Unlike prior research that often associates upward comparison with negative experiences (Lockwood & Kunda, 1997, 1999), we find that upward comparison in this context elicits benign envy, reinforcing organizational commitment. This suggests that gig employees may view formal employees not only as competitors but also as aspirational models, extending the scope of assimilation effects into nonstandard work arrangements. Conversely, while downward comparison has been linked to higher affective commitment among formal employees (Brown et al., 2007), for gig employees it induces malicious envy and undermines commitment. This reversal may stem from cognitive dissonance created by perceiving oneself as more skilled yet less institutionally valued, given the inherent identity advantages of formal employees (Aronson, 1969). Moreover, although competitive climates are typically thought to amplify contrast effects (Stapel & Koomen, 2005), our results reveal a different dynamic: competition signals opportunities for recognition and advancement, thereby shifting gig employees' focus toward similarities with formal employees and fostering assimilation-driven emotions. Taken together, these findings demonstrate that emotional responses to social comparisons are dual and context-contingent. They highlight how benign and malicious envy operate as differentiated mechanisms shaping gig employees' organizational attitudes, offering a more nuanced and contextually grounded extension of social comparison theory in the gig economy.

Second, Our study extends envy theory by embedding the benign/malicious envy mechanism within the distinctive conditions of gig employment. Specifically, we highlight how identity ambiguity makes gig employees highly sensitive to social comparisons, since their unstable and peripheral position intensifies concerns about self-esteem and belonging (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Caza et al., 2022). We further show that the desire for legitimacy transforms the meaning of upward comparisons. While prior studies often associate upward comparison with threat and discouragement (Lockwood & Kunda, 1997, 1999), gig employees tend to interpret the advantages of formal employees as rooted in structural identity differences rather than innate superiority. Because these advantages—such as stability, security, and belonging—are viewed as attainable through skill development and effort, gig workers are more likely to engage in similarity testing and assimilation, resulting in benign envy that motivates self-improvement and enhances organizational commitment (Smith & Kim, 2007). At the same time, the flexible and blurred boundaries between gig and formal employees introduce a unique dynamic in downward comparisons. Even when gig workers perceive themselves as superior in expertise or contributions, they remain excluded from the identity privileges of formal membership. This incongruence fosters dissimilarity testing and contrast, generating malicious envy that undermines cooperation and erodes commitment (Petriglieri, 2011; Van de Ven et al., 2012). Taken together, these findings reveal that envy in gig contexts follows a distinct causal pathway, shaped by identity ambiguity, legitimacy needs, and fluid boundaries, thereby extending envy theory into non-standard work arrangements.

Third, we reveal an emotional mechanism in the gig context that influences gig employee's organizational commitment. The emotional experience of gig employees deserves particular attention, due to the diverse threats they face, such as verbal abuse, safety concerns, and the potential for low ratings (Ladegaard et al., 2022; Wu & Huang, 2024). As emphasized by Cropanzano et al. (2023), "Commitment, then, seems to have costs for gig workers that are less salient among standard workers"

(p.24). Moreover, Cropanzano et al. (2023) further note that gig employees' commitment is not necessarily lacking but rather multifaceted and flexible, directed toward various targets such as their job, staffing agencies, or personal life instead of the organization. Research on how to strengthen gig employees' commitment to the organization remains limited. This study finds that benign envy fosters organizational commitment by redirecting gig employees' commitment toward the organization, whereas malicious envy drives them away, reducing commitment. These findings deepen our understanding of strategies to enhance gig employees' organizational commitment.

Finally, we contribute to the competitive psychological climate literature by highlighting its positive effects on employee's emotional states. While prior research associates a competitive psychological climate with tense team dynamics and unethical behavior (Jiang et al., 2016; Liu et al., 2023), our findings suggest otherwise for gig employees. Specifically, under high competitive psychological climate, gig employee's upward social comparison is more likely to trigger benign envy, strengthening organizational commitment. By focusing on knowledge-based gig employees, we reveal unique psychological mechanisms in their social comparison processes, offering a more nuanced understanding of competition's varying effects across different employee groups.

5.2. Practical implications

First, the specific form of gig employment examined in this study is becoming increasingly common in technology, digital services, and innovation-driven sectors. Although these gig employees lacked formal employment contracts, they were deeply embedded in organizational teams during project cycles and collaborated closely with formal employees. This "semi-integrated" status, characterized by high task interdependence but institutional peripherality, reflects a growing organizational reality. Therefore, our sample offers a relevant and realistic context for generalizing findings to similar work arrangements that blend flexibility with team integration. Organizations should recognize that social comparisons between gig employees and formal employees are inevitable. To enhance gig employees' organizational commitment, organizations should foster positive forms of social comparison. Mentorship programs and high-quality relationships between formal and gig employees (Cropanzano et al., 2023; Subramony, 2014) can help gig employees observe and learn from formal employees, triggering upward comparisons and positive emotional responses (e.g., benign envy) that align their behaviors with organizational goals.

Second, our findings suggest organizations should minimize factors that lead to downward comparisons, as these may trigger malicious envy and weaken gig employee's commitment. Creating an inclusive work climate (Cropanzano et al., 2023) can help both gig and formal employees feel valued, reducing negative emotions from downward comparisons. Additionally, organizations should provide psychological support services (Liden et al., 2003; Veitch & Cooper-Thomas, 2009), such as mental health counseling and anonymous support platforms, to help gig employees manage negative emotions like malicious envy. Understanding the impact of social comparisons on gig employees' emotions and behaviors allows organizations to design incentive mechanisms that foster a positive work environment and strengthen commitment. Optimizing the competitive psychological climate can enhance benign envy while mitigating malicious envy, promoting a healthier social comparison culture. However, as competition can be a double-edged sword—motivating employees while potentially undermining collaboration and increasing burnout (Lee et al., 2022)—organizations should approach it cautiously by incorporating contingent rewards and ensuring high organizational justice.

Finally, our findings offer several actionable implications for managers seeking to reduce downward comparisons and malicious envy in mixed workforces. At the organizational level, companies should design performance evaluation and reward systems that emphasize expertise,

project contributions, and innovation outcomes rather than contract type. Providing gig employees with transparent recognition pathways (e.g., “Outstanding Contributor Awards” open to all) signals fairness and diminishes resentment. They should also consider gig-specific systems such as digital collaboration platforms that facilitate real-time knowledge-sharing and make gig employees' expertise visible, thereby narrowing perceived identity gaps with formal employees. At the team level, managers can structure work to promote collaboration rather than competition—for example, assigning interdependent tasks, forming mixed project teams, or implementing hybrid mentorship programs where formal employees support gig employees' social integration while gig employees share niche skills. These reciprocal arrangements highlight complementarities rather than differences. At the individual level, HR policies can affirm gig employees' identity by including them in training programs, career development initiatives, and symbolic recognition events such as showcasing their achievements in internal newsletters or town hall meetings. Project-based recognition mechanisms provide further symbolic affirmation of gig workers' value, reducing malicious envy. Finally, regular communication campaigns that highlight success stories of gig–formal collaboration can reframe comparisons from identity differences toward collective success. Together, these interventions address both general workforce challenges and gig-specific dynamics, helping organizations redirect social comparisons into constructive rather than destructive pathways and strengthening gig employees' organizational commitment.

5.3. Limitations and directions for future research

First, our research focus on the emotional outcomes of gig employees, future research could extend our research by examining performance-related outcomes of gig employees, such as gig employee's task performance, engagement and proactivity. It is also important to consider how the emotional reactions of gig employees dynamically evolve over time (Lange et al., 2018). For instance, gig employees may initially experience higher levels of benign envy toward formal employees, as they admire the latter's job stability and access to organizational resources (Caza et al., 2018) and view these advantages as aspirational goals. However, as projects progress, if gig employees come to realize that such goals are unattainable, their benign envy may gradually shift into malicious envy. Future research could employ more extensive longitudinal designs to explore how gig employees' social comparisons and feelings of envy toward formal employees change over time. This approach would provide deeper insights into the temporal dynamics of these emotional reactions and their potential implications for organizational behavior.

Second, our research is particularly focused on competitive psychological climate in shaping the effect of social comparison on envy. We measure the competitive psychological climate perceived by gig employees. In the future, data at the team level or even at the organizational level can be obtained, which would provide a more accurate aggregation of the team or organizational competitive climate. Moreover, future research could extend ours by investigating other boundary conditions. For example, the gig employee's self-esteem may be a variable relevant in the social comparison context (Aspinwall & Taylor, 1993). For these gig employees with high self-esteem, they may less be influenced by the social comparison. In addition, the compared formal employee's characteristics, such as humility, can be another moderator. We conjecture that the compared formal employee's humility may influence gig employee's emotional reactions, such that gig employees experience less malicious envy and more benign envy toward the formal employees who is perceived as humble. Future research could examine these individual-level moderators to complement the organizational-level lens adopted here.

Third, despite our efforts to reduce common method bias (e.g., ensuring anonymity, multi-wave design), the use of self-report data still raises concerns regarding common method bias. Future research may

benefit from incorporating alternative data sources such as supervisor ratings, behavioral tracking, or real-time text analysis (e.g., work logs or communication records) to better capture employees' psychological reactions and mitigate same-source bias. Besides, we note that the hypothesized moderated mediation of malicious envy (H8) was not supported. One likely explanation is the collectivist cultural context of China, which may suppress hostile emotional expression and dampen observable effects. In addition, our single-organization design may have constrained variability in competitive psychological climate perceptions, limiting statistical power. These contextual and methodological factors suggest that the null result should be interpreted with caution and warrants replication in more diverse settings.

Fourth, there may be concerns regarding the generalizability of our results. Probst and Lawler (2006) have shown that collectivist employees react more negatively than individualist employees to the threat of job insecurity. The Chinese context is theoretically meaningful for examining gig–formal employee social comparison, because the collectivist cultural orientation may amplify gig employees' need for identity affirmation and belonging, thereby intensifying their tendency to engage in social comparison with formal employees. Future research is needed to examine whether similar social comparison processes occur in more individualistic cultures, where gig employees may value autonomy and independence over organizational belonging. In addition, although the present study failed to find a significant moderated mediating effect of competitive psychological climate on the mediating effect of malicious envy between downward social comparison and organizational commitment, these results may be due to our limited sample size and collectivist cultural background. In collectivist contexts such as China, employees may be more likely to suppress hostile emotions and prioritize harmony, which reduces the salience of malicious envy as a mediating mechanism. In addition, our data were collected from a single large technology platform company in China. This organization, comparable in scale and influence to Alibaba, is one of the leading hubs for knowledge-intensive gig workers. This context makes it highly relevant for examining the dynamics of gig–formal employee social comparison. However, relying on a single company inevitably limits the generalizability of our findings. Future research should replicate and extend our study across different industries and organizational contexts to strengthen external validity.

Finally, future research could further benefit from adopting comparative designs. One promising direction is to conduct comparisons between gig and formal employees to examine whether employment status moderates social comparison processes and their emotional consequences. Another avenue is to compare gig workers across different industries, such as technology platforms, creative industries, and professional services. Work design differences—for example, task autonomy, skill specificity, and team interdependence—may shape whether benign or malicious envy predominates, thereby influencing organizational commitment differently. Such comparative studies would sharpen our understanding of the contextual boundaries of social comparison mechanisms.

6. Conclusion

Based on social comparison theory, we discover that social comparison is not only prevalent within organizations but also exists between external employees (i.e., gig employees) and formal employees. Accordingly, we elaborate on the nature and unique mechanisms of gig employee's social comparisons. We find that gig employees engage in both upward and downward social comparisons with formal employees. Contrary to previous findings in social comparison theory, our study reveals that upward comparisons between gig and formal employees lead to benign envy and increased organizational commitment, while downward comparisons result in more malicious envy and reduced organizational commitment. Furthermore, we find the moderating role of competitive psychological climate.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Liuyan Li: Writing – original draft, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Xiaoming Zheng:** Data curation, Conceptualization. **Xiaoxuan Li:** Writing – original draft, Methodology, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Gerui Zhao:** Methodology. **Huiying Zhang:** Writing – original draft.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no conflict of interest.

Data availability

The data are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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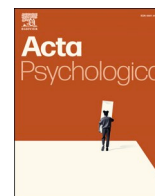
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Corrigendum



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